Still Speaking

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Still Speaking: A Theological Rebuttal Against the Cessationist Misreading of Pentecost

By John P. Kennon

Introduction

The Holy Spirit has not retired.

Yet, in modern theological circles, we increasingly encounter efforts to relegate the outpouring of the Spirit and its manifestations—especially speaking in tongues and prophecy—to a museum of early church history. A recent commentary I read attempts precisely this, claiming that apostolic expressions of power were uniquely confined to redemptive history, not intended for the church today. This rebuttal aims to dismantle that assertion biblically, theologically, and logically.

1. Apostolic Activity Is Not Apostolic Exclusivity

The argument that 'apostles and prophets did things not meant for ordinary believers' is a theological sleight of hand that ignores the participatory nature of New Testament Christianity.

Scripture is clear:
“These signs shall follow them that believe...” (Mark 16:17) — not only apostles.
“The promise is unto you, and to your children, and to all that are afar off...” (Acts 2:39)

Spiritual manifestations in Acts are often initiated by apostles but experienced by lay believers. In Acts 10, it was Cornelius and his household who spoke in tongues — not the apostles. The gifts of the Spirit are not badges of office, but gifts to the Body (1 Cor. 12:7).

This is dangerously dismissive logic. Yes, apostles and prophets had foundational roles (Eph. 2:20), but the power, gifts, and signs they moved in were never theirs alone — they were a normative expectation for the Spirit-filled believer. If the same Spirit that raised Christ from the dead dwells in us (Rom. 8:11), why should we expect less?

2. Pentecost Was Historic — and Prophetic

Yes, Pentecost was a hinge point in redemptive history — a reversal of Babel (Gen. 11), an inauguration of the Church Age. But to claim the evidence of Spirit baptism is to be retired like a trophy in a case is a half-truth dressed in scholarly robes.

Acts 10:44-46 – Gentiles spoke with tongues and magnified God.
Acts 19:6 – Paul laid hands, they spoke with tongues and prophesied.
Acts 8:17-19 – Simon saw something so tangible it made him want to buy the power!

These are not one-off theatrical events — they are patterns. In Jerusalem (Acts 2), Samaria (Acts 8), Caesarea (Acts 10), and Ephesus (Acts 19), we see consistent replication of the Pentecostal template: faith, repentance, water baptism, and Spirit baptism with the sign of tongues.

If the gospel is still for every nation, then so is the Pentecostal outpouring.

3. Redemptive-Historical Arguments Fail the Continuity Test

The assertion that certain signs 'should not be expected in subsequent generations' conflicts with the continuity of Scripture.

Paul did not suggest a timeline or expiration date on the gifts. Rather:
• “I would that ye all spake with tongues…” (1 Cor. 14:5)
• “Forbid not to speak with tongues.” (1 Cor. 14:39)

This was written decades after Pentecost, to a Gentile congregation, without the presence of apostles. No hint of spiritual gifts being phased out. If the Spirit hasn’t changed, then the manifestation of that Spirit hasn’t changed either.

4. The Danger of Theological Reductionism

The writer’s approach exemplifies cessationist theology: exalting historical context over biblical command. Theology must draw its meaning from Scripture (exegesis), not impose it (eisegesis).

Limiting the Holy Spirit’s work to a historical snapshot:
• Contradicts Acts 2:39's open-ended invitation
• Ignores countless modern testimonies of Spirit baptism
• Denies centuries of spiritual outpouring and revival

We are still in the 'last days' — Joel 2:28 remains active. If Jesus still baptizes with the Holy Ghost and fire, then tongues still follow (Matt. 3:11; Mark 16:17).

5. Let God Be True and Every Scholar a Liar

When scholarship clashes with lived spiritual experience and the biblical pattern, Scripture must win. The Spirit still speaks. The gifts still operate. The same fire that fell in Acts 2 is still falling.

“Jesus Christ the same yesterday, and today, and forever.” (Heb. 13:8)

This is not theology from a museum — Pentecost didn’t happen in a display case. It broke out in an upper room and has never stopped. The gifts are alive. The tongues still flow. The power still falls. Let the fire fall again.